The Five-Minute Daily Frame

Tantra for beginners: breath, sound and movement, ninety seconds each

by Lawrence Lanoff

Excerpted from Beyond the Myth: The Definitive Guide to Modern Tantra, Chapter 27. Free reading copy. For adults (18+). Education, not therapy or medical care.
tantra-authority.com

You have a body. You have five minutes. That is enough.

That sentence is the whole chapter. Everything after it is just the shape of how to spend the five minutes — what to do, why these particular things and not others, and how the body lets you know it is working.

I want the bar low. On purpose. Most people who pick up a book like this one walk away with a list. Twenty minutes of breath. Thirty of meditation. An hour of body practice. Journaling. A partner check-in. A cold plunge if you are feeling holy that day. The list looks beautiful on paper. The list is the thing that fails. Three weeks in, it falls apart, and you go back to where you started — only now you are carrying the extra weight of having failed at it.

So we build against that. The five-minute frame is the smallest practice that still changes the body that does it. It is what you can do on the bad day. The busy day. The hung-over day. The day you slept four hours. It is small enough that the part of you that argues I don't have time has nothing to grab onto. And it is precise enough that, done daily, it reshapes you. Over weeks. Over months. Over years.

If you do nothing else from this entire book — do this.

Three things. Ninety seconds each.

One breath practice. One sound practice. One movement practice. Ninety seconds each. With the spaces, it takes about five minutes.

You do them in that order, every day, at roughly the same time. Morning suits most bodies — you have just come out of sleep, the day has not yet loaded its appointments onto your nervous system, and the practice sets the tone for the hours behind it. If morning can't happen in your life, pick another anchor. Before lunch. After work. Before bed. The exact hour matters far less than the same hour. The body learns the rhythm. It starts pre-loading for it. After a few weeks you'll catch yourself moving toward the practice the way you move toward coffee — the body has folded it into what a day is made of.

I'm not going to overbuild this. The simpler I keep it, the more likely your body actually does it. The more I decorate it, the faster it joins the pile of things you should be doing and never do.

The breath — long exhale, ninety seconds

Inhale through the nose, four counts. Exhale through the nose, eight counts. Ninety seconds. That's it.

I walked you through what's happening underneath, back in chapter two. The short of it: when the exhale grows long, the body slides from on toward open — the side of you that rests, digests, repairs, gets aroused, gets curious, comes home into itself. For most people the shift lands inside about four breath cycles. Ninety seconds is room enough for it to arrive and settle in.

Seated. Standing. Lying down. In the bathroom. In the car before you walk into the building. In bed before your feet hit the floor. The posture doesn't matter. What matters is that you let the exhale run twice as long as the inhale, and you give it the full ninety seconds — no phone, no planning the morning in the background. Just the breath, getting long.

And if four-and-eight is more than your lungs want right now, drop it to three and six. If it's too easy, take it to five and ten. The exact numbers don't carry the weight. The two-to-one — exhale twice as long as inhale — that's what carries it. The body is listening to the ratio. Whatever the ratio says, the body believes.

Watch for two things. The first: don't rush the inhale to get to the long exhale faster. Let the inhale be its own slow thing. It matters too. The body is learning smoothness across the whole wave, not just the half you're stretching. The second: the count is not a test. It's a banister for your attention, something to rest your hand on — not a math problem you can fail. Lose count, start again at one, keep going. Nobody grades you on whether you held four-eight perfectly. You spent ninety seconds slowing the breath. You did the thing.

The sound — voiced exhale, ninety seconds

This is the one most people skip. They skip it because somewhere along the way they got told to be quiet, and the body remembers. Don't skip it. The sound is doing work the breath can't do alone.

Inhale through the nose. On the exhale, let the breath have a voice. The simplest version is an open ahhhh — mouth open, jaw soft, throat loose, the breath moving through the cords without push. Not loud. Not a performance. Just audible. Held for the length of the exhale.

Ninety seconds.

Here's why it's worth the discomfort, said plainly. The cords live in the throat, wrapped in some of the richest concentrations of vagus nerve in the whole body — the same nerve the long exhale was already coaxing toward open. So the sound is a second road into the same place. While that's happening, the voiced exhale tends to spring open the jaw, the throat, the chest, the diaphragm — exactly the zones most of us clench shut all day without knowing it. The habitual day keeps the voice small, the throat half-gripped, the jaw set, the chest braced. Ninety seconds of sound walks in and unlocks the pattern. The throat opens. The jaw drops. The chest lets go. The body remembers that the voice is allowed to take up room.

If you can't make sound out loud where you are — roommates, thin walls, a sleeping partner, a desk you can't leave — the practice still works low. A whispered, breathy ahhhh gives you most of it. The cords still hum. The throat still opens. The body still gets the message that sound is being made. So don't skip it for lack of volume. Turn the volume down and do it.

And if you can be loud — let the sound be a real sound. Not loud-as-show. Real. The sigh that's been waiting in there a while. The voice the body would make if it knew no one was listening. The body will often start moving the sound around on its own — a hum, a moan, a sob, a yawn-noise, a laugh. Let it. The body knows what sound it needs to make today. Your only job is to give it the ninety seconds and stay out of its way.

The discomfort some of you feel hearing your own uncoded voice — that discomfort is information. It tells you how long the voice has been held in. And it fades fast. Usually inside a week of daily practice. A throat that's been holding for thirty years can learn to let go in less time than it took to lock down. Do the sound piece. It's doing things the others can't.

The movement — spinal hinge, ninety seconds

The body has been still for hours — asleep, or just woken, or folded over a desk. The movement undoes the stillness.

The simplest version is a spinal hinge from standing. Feet about hip width. Knees soft. Inhale, lift the arms overhead, let the spine go long. Exhale, fold forward from the hips, let the head and arms hang heavy toward the floor. Inhale, roll slowly back up, one vertebra at a time. Exhale, fold again.

Ninety seconds. Slow. Not stretching, not pushing. We're not chasing flexibility. We're letting the spine move — waking the muscles, getting the blood going, opening the hips, letting the breath pour into a body that's finally asking for it.

If standing won't work — bad back, an injury, a mobility limit — do it from a chair. Seated, spine long on the inhale, fold gently forward over the thighs on the exhale, rise slow on the inhale. Same shape. Same ninety seconds.

And if you already have a movement practice — yoga, mobility work, qigong, dance — this ninety seconds doesn't replace it. It's the floor, not the ceiling. The long practice is whatever you lay on top. This is what makes sure something moved, even on the days the long practice never arrives.

What it does in the body: it wakes up your sense of where you are in space — proprioception, one of the three channels of knowing from chapter one. It calls the trunk and the hips back into use after most of a life of underuse. It moves the fluids that move when you move and pool when you sit. It brings oxygen to the tissue. And it tells the nervous system the simple true thing — you are a body, not a container for a brain.

The breath set the nervous system. The sound opened the channel. The movement is the body saying I have arrived in the day. Five minutes. You're done.

Why small-and-daily beats big-and-someday

Let me tell you why I'm keeping this so small instead of handing you the elaborate practice the rest of the book has been hinting at. The reason is structural, not philosophical.

The body doesn't learn what it does once. The body learns what it does every day. The reps build the wiring. The wiring doesn't come from rare heroic sessions — it comes from small, daily, almost-too-easy repetition, laid down over time.

Do the arithmetic and it gets strange. Ninety minutes of breath once a week is six hours a month, and it gives you modest results. Ninety seconds of breath every day is forty-five minutes a month — a fraction of the time — and it gives you dramatic ones. Fewer hours. Bigger change. It's not the total time. It's how often the body gets touched by it.

Many small exposures move the body faster than a few large ones. It's true for breath. True for sound. True for movement. True for solo erotic practice, partnered practice, meditation — nearly every practice in this whole book.

the big practice fails, the small one doesn't. The person who's committed to the hour-long morning routine skips it on every day the hour isn't there — which, in the life you're actually living, is most days. The five-minute frame is available on every day that there is a day. You can't argue it away. You can't defer it. I'll do it later when I have more time finds nothing to push against in five minutes.

Somebody I trust said it cleaner than I can: the practice you can actually do is infinitely better than the practice you can't. And the difference really is infinite. The five minutes you do every day will, across a year, reshape the body more than the ninety-minute practice you meant to do daily and got to four times.

Start small enough that you cannot reasonably fail. Grow it once it's grown roots. The roots come from the daily reps. They never come from the ambition.

What to add when the five minutes lives in your bones

After a few months the frame integrates. The body does it without a fight. And you'll want more.

First thing to add: more time inside the same three. Not new pieces — more of these. The breath can stretch from ninety seconds to four minutes. So can the sound. So can the movement. The same three things, longer. Same shape, deeper.

Second thing to add: one chapter from this book, worked daily for a month. Pick one — touch, solo practice, partner practice, sex magic, the Vijñāna Bhairava practices, whichever one is calling — and run one practice from it every day for a month on top of the frame. At month's end, look. Some practices become permanent. Some turn out to have been right for that month and no longer. The body sorts it.

Third thing to add: partnered practice on a steady rhythm, if you have a partner who's on the same page. Next: what that looks like. Same shape as the solo — start small, stay steady, let it grow roots before you add anything.

What I would not add, at any stage, is the cluster of workshops followed by nothing in between. The big-workshop-then-silence pattern is exactly what produces the wave of openness and the slow slide back to baseline that so many people in this field ride around and around forever. The daily five-minute frame is the cure for that. It makes small, durable, cumulative change. The workshops can feed it. They can't replace it.

How the body tells you it's working

Everyone asks this. And the honest answer is: it shows up in the places you weren't watching.

You won't notice on day seven that you slept better. On day fourteen you'll notice the conversation with your difficult coworker didn't hook you the way it always does. On day thirty you'll notice you stopped reaching for the second drink at dinner. On day sixty your partner will say you seem different — more present, less wound up, easier to be near. On day ninety someone will ask what changed, and you won't quite know how to answer, because it happened in the background and surfaces only as you, more relaxed than before.

That's how the signals come. Sideways. The body is regulating better. There's more room in the open setting. The chronic low hum of tension you'd been carrying as your baseline has quietly dropped its volume. Nothing dramatic ever happened. The dramatic got scattered across thousands of small moments, and the sum of them is what the body now is, instead of what it used to be.

If you want concrete markers to watch, here are a few:

Sleep. Do you fall asleep faster, stay asleep, wake more rested. The frame done morning and again before bed often shifts sleep noticeably inside two weeks.

Reactivity. When something goes wrong, how long until the nervous system comes back down. The gap between the trigger and the recovery is a real, measurable thing — and it tends to shrink.

Sexual responsiveness. Solo or partnered: does arousal come easier, does the body feel more, does pleasure last longer. The breath and sound work in particular tend to move this within weeks.

The morning baseline. What does the body feel like in the first hour after waking. The frame done inside that first hour tends to make the whole morning lighter, less anxious, more present.

Don't track all of them. Pick one. Notice it weekly. And don't expect a straight line — some weeks jump, some plateau, some look like backsliding. The trend across months is the thing. The trend is what the daily reps are quietly building.

And if, after three honest months of daily practice, you're noticing nothing at all — that's information too. It means something specific in your body isn't getting traction with this particular setup. The move there is not to quit. The move is to bring it to a teacher who can look at what you're doing and adjust it. The practice works in nearly every body that does it consistently. The exceptions almost always have a specific factor underneath — a medication, a trauma layer, a sleep disorder, a thyroid thing — that wants more than a book can give. Get that looked at. Then come back to the frame.

The closing instruction

Tomorrow morning, before anything else, sit somewhere quiet for five minutes. Inhale four, exhale eight, for ninety seconds. Voice the exhale, ninety seconds. Move the spine, ninety seconds. Then go on with your day.

Do it again the day after. And the day after that. Every day this week. Then into the next.

If you miss a day, don't catch up. Just resume the next morning. The missed day breaks nothing. What breaks the practice is treating the miss as a failure you have to atone for. The body forgives the missed day easily. What the body doesn't recover from is the abandonment that comes when you turn one missed day into a referendum on whether you should be doing this at all. Don't hold that trial. Just resume.

Five minutes is the frame. The frame is what changes the body. And the body is what carries everything else this book has been about.

Get the frame in. The rest follows.

Where to go next

If this landed, the next step is one of my two short books, written for one reader at a time.

Tantra for Men (eBook), $19.97

Tantra for Women (eBook), $19.97

And when you want the full program, step by step: Tantra X, $197.

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